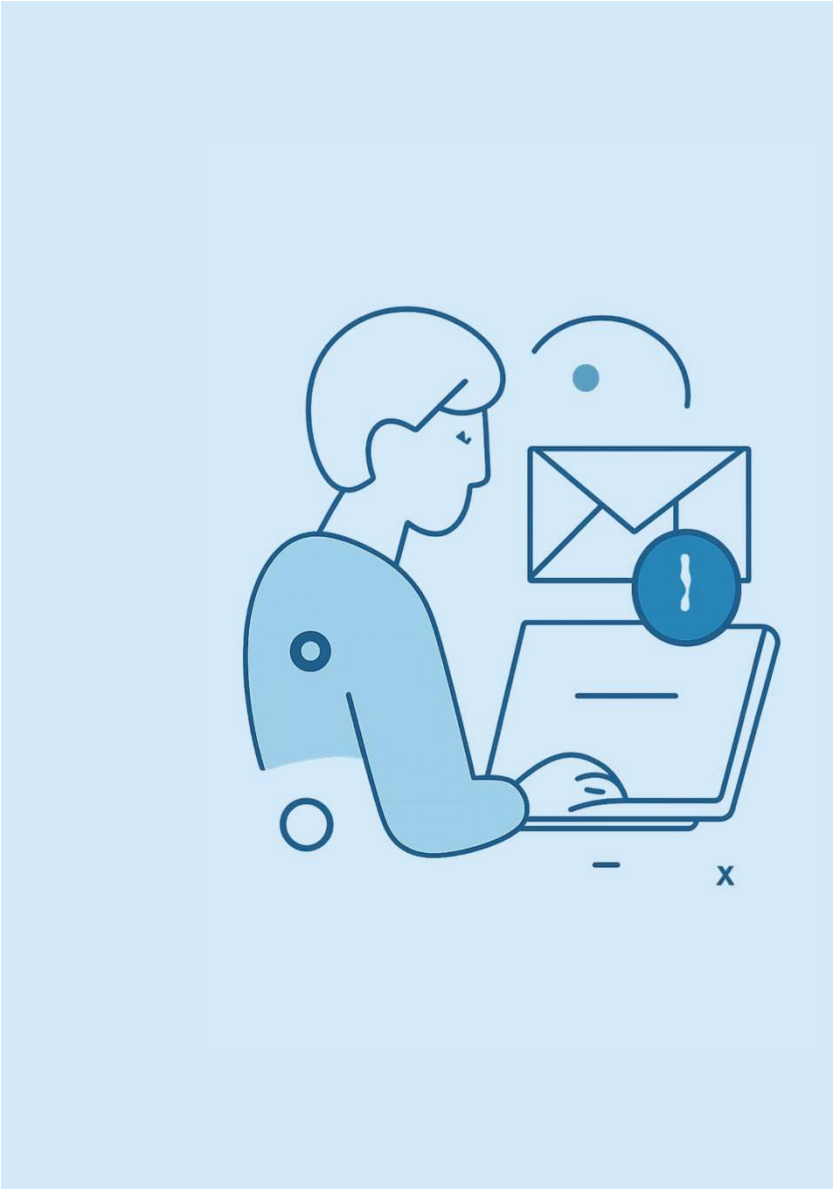
Phishing: Don't Get Hooked! Your Guide to Online Safety

Short, practical training to help you recognize phishing, understand attacker tactics, and adopt simple defenses you can use today.

The Invisible Threat: What is Phishing?

Phishing is social engineering that impersonates trusted sources to steal credentials, money, or access. Attackers blend deception, urgency, and technical tricks — often pairing phishing with malware or network attacks. Losses have surged worldwide; awareness is the first defense.



The Social Engineering Playbook

Urgency & Fear

Messages pressure you to act now — account closures, security alerts, or penalties.

Curiosity & Excitement

Fake prizes, shocking videos, or sensational headlines lure clicks and downloads.

Authority & Trust

Impersonation of banks, partners, or executives makes requests seem legitimate.

Scarcity

Limited-time offers or one-off opportunities force rushed decisions.

Decoding the Phish: Recognizing Suspicious Emails

Check the Sender

Look for slight misspellings, extra characters, or odd domains (e.g., my-bank.com vs mybank.com).

Greeting & Tone

Generic salutations, pressure language, or inconsistent writing are red flags.

Links & Attachments

Hover to reveal the true URL. Never open unexpected attachments — treat .zip/.exe/docx with caution.

Requests for Credentials

Legitimate organizations rarely ask for passwords, PINs, or verification codes via email.

Spotting Fake Websites

Quick checks before entering data:

- URL match — domain and subdomain matter (pay.attention.example ≠ example).
- HTTPS & padlock — presence helps but is not a guarantee.
- Design & content quality — typos, odd logos, or broken links can indicate fraud.
- Unexpected credential prompts — stop and verify via a known site or phone number.

Real-World Phishing Disasters: Lessons Learned

Spear Phishing

Highly tailored emails use public profile data to trick targets into transferring funds or revealing credentials.

Whaling

Attackers target executives with high-value requests — the impact can be millions in losses or severe data breaches.

Smishing & Vishing

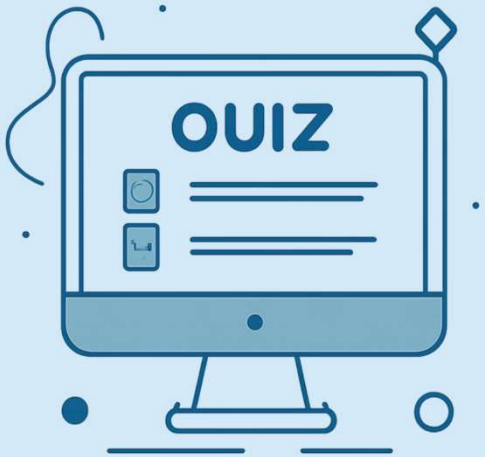
SMS and phone-based scams pressure or deceive people into sharing codes, clicking links, or authorizing actions.

Interactive Quiz: Can You Spot the Phish?

Scenario 1: Email from "PayPal Support" asks you to click to verify suspicious activity. — What do you do?
Scenario 2: Text claims you won an iPhone; link asks for shipping details. — Is it safe?
Scenario 3: Email from your "CEO" urgently requests gift card purchases and codes.

Answers (check after making your choice)

1) Don't click — open a new browser and sign in via the official site or contact support. 2) Ignore and report — prize scams are common. 3) Verify via phone or in-person — financial requests from executives should be confirmed through an independent channel.



Best Practices: Your Digital Defense Shield

Pause & Verify

Think before clicking — a brief pause prevents mistakes.

Independent Verification

Use known phone numbers/URLs to confirm requests.

Report Quickly

Forward suspicious messages to security or use the organization's reporting tool.

Protect Your Accounts

Use strong, unique passwords and enable MFA for all sensitive accounts.

Keep Systems Updated

Apply OS and app patches to reduce exploit risk.

Limit Data Exposure

Share minimal personal info on social profiles to reduce targeting material.

The Human Element: You Are the First Line of Defense

Technology helps, but human judgment catches context cues filters miss. Practice spotting social-engineering tactics, ask questions, and model cautious behavior. Encourage a culture where reporting mistakes is safe — quick reporting limits damage.

Tip: If you suspect you clicked a malicious link, disconnect from the network, change passwords from a safe device, and notify IT immediately.

Stay Vigilant, Stay Safe!

Phishing evolves — so should your habits. Follow the checks in this module: verify senders, inspect links, enable MFA, and report suspicious messages. Share these tips with colleagues and help build a stronger, safer organization.

Practice

Run mock phishing quizzes regularly.

Protect

Use MFA and password managers.

Report

Make reporting fast and simple.